



Figure 2: KOffice applications

AuFS (Another Union File System) to stack each of the SquashFS modules. It boots using the initrd, which has the AuFS drivers, then inserts each module from the base directory. When it's done, all modules from the modules directory are inserted. Finally, KDE is started!

What else?

Customised versions of Slax don't have to be built manually. You can get a custom build from the website. Go to www.slax.com/build.php. Add or remove any modules you may want. As of now, you can choose between 1,284 modules. When you are done, use the links to download a TAR or ISO. There are some limitations, such as non-resumable downloads, lack of personalisation options, etc, but for now, a rudimentary set-up like this works okay.

Derivatives

Slax is a very modular and layman-customisable distro. Thus it is no surprise that derivatives start springing up all over the place. Linvo [linvo.linux-bg.org] deserves a special mention. It is a GNOME-based Slax-derived distro that is by all means complete. It includes Wine, Firefox and Code:Blocks for development (they just hit my soft corner with Code:Blocks). Linvo can be used as a minimalist home

distro that includes one app for every task you need to perform.

The bottom line

Slax 6.0.9 is as always a heck of a distribution. It's by no means a distro you would use for recovery purposes; for that, SystemRescueCd is the one and only choice -- but as a minimalist distribution, it is very complete. One possible use is that you could create a Persistent LiveUSB with Slax and carry it around with all your files. This way you have an entire computer in your pocket, which just needs a... well, computer, to run. For basic recovery purposes (such as an OS crash or back-up restore) Slax can work, and you can use it as the main OS in lower speed or prehistoric computers (it just needs 128 MB of RAM to work). It's very uncomplicated, and can be used by beginners or teachers to teach Linux (from an end-user viewpoint). Overall, it is a worthy upgrade to any Slax fan, Slackware fan, Linux lover, Linux hater... well, just about everybody.

Postscript: Linux Live Scripts

Slax is from a stock Slackware installation and a customised kernel. And the good news is, the entire build system is available for you to use and is distro-independent. So if you want to build Ubuntu-Slax, Debian-Slax or



Figure 3: K3b CD burner and KPlayer media player

Fedora-Slax, or just about any Slax, start by installing LZMA, AuFS and SquashFS. Then get the kernel source and patch it to support all of these. Finally, go to www.linux-live.org and download the live scripts. Execute them to get your own Slax ISO. All instructions are available in detail at the Linux-live website. Remember, by this method, anything in your system's filesystem is included in the Live distro.



Slax 6.0.9



Pros:

Minimalist yet complete, fast boot-up time, easy to use, lots of boot-up features, small size. Oh yes, it works faster than a Saturn V rocket.

Cons:

No updated software, no bootplash... well, actually nothing serious to complain about.

Platform:

x86 (No separate version for x86_64)

Price:

Free (as in beer)

Website:

www.slax.org

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